

Re-centering Domestic Work: the Late Medieval Jurists, Panel: Care work. Counting and understanding care work and domestic work in the societies of the past (WP: Labour and Family Economy), 6th European Labour History Network Conference. University of Barcelona - 18 June 2026, Barcelona, Spain.

Despite a certain marginality in legal-historical scholarship, “domestic work” was anything but peripheral in late-medieval legal systems. The inherited Roman notion of work, “*operae*”, occurs chiefly in the Digest title *De operis libertorum* (D. 38.1), where it is treated as an asset deeply inherent to the Roman household. Drawing on a body of late-medieval scholastic writings known as the *distinctiones operarum*, this paper builds on this premise. It asks what “domestic work” meant for late-medieval jurists and, more broadly, what role it played in the economies of their times. The “house” did not simply denote a range of working activities. Rather, it functioned as a far broader institution for valuing and regulating work at large.

Edited with Claude (Anthropic)